

What Interviewers *Actually* Write Down

Five exercises to build the judgment stories interviewers score — before you walk into the next room.

NAME

DATE

NEXT INTERVIEW DATE

1

Write Your Own 'Why Not' Line

- Name **one project** where you picked a model, metric, or method.
- Write the *alternative* you rejected — not just what you chose.
- Finish: **"I chose X over Y"** because ____.
- No alternative comes to mind? That's the gap they'll flag.

YOUR TRADEOFF LINE

2

Find Your Leakage Story

- Recall a result that looked **too good**, or a mistake caught before it shipped.
- Sentence 1: what looked wrong.
- Sentence 2: how you *caught* it.
- Sentence 3: what you did next.

YOUR 3-SENTENCE STORY

3

Business-Cost the Metric

- Pick a project where you optimized **accuracy, AUC, RMSE**, or similar.
- Write what that metric cost or saved — *dollars, time, users*.
- Blank? Go find the number before your next interview.

METRIC → BUSINESS COST

4

Draft Your One Real Question

- Write **one question** about the team's actual work — not perks.
- Model: *"What's the messiest dataset you're fighting right now?"*
- Or: *"Where does this model actually break in production?"*
- Say it out loud once before the interview.

YOUR REAL QUESTION

5

Pressure-Test an Underspecified Prompt

- Take a vague ask: **"build a model to predict churn."**
- Before touching code, write the *clarifying question* you'd ask first.
- What decision is this number actually feeding?
- Compare to your instinct to just start building. That gap is what gets scored.

CLARIFY BEFORE BUILD